

Surfin' U.S.A. -- The Beach Boys (Guitar)

Type: Song

Instrument: Stratocaster (HSS)

Full Board: Yes

BPM: ~158 (estimate)

The song

"Surfin' U.S.A." (1963), title track of the second album.

The melody is lifted from Chuck Berry's "Sweet Little Sixteen", and the guitar follows Berry's playbook too.

Rhythm: a straight-8th boogie chug. Root-fifth to root-sixth shapes on the low strings, clean and bright.

Lead: Carl Wilson's Chuck Berry-style lines, double-stop bends and fast pull-offs.

Early-60s Fender clean everywhere. Spring reverb is part of the sound, but this is vocal surf, not a drenched Dick Dale instrumental. The reverb supports the parts, it doesn't wash them out.

CTL Off = rhythm chug (verses, choruses).

CTL On = lead lines (intro fills and the instrumental break).

Pickups: position 2 (bridge + middle) for the rhythm, bright and a little quacky, like a single-coil Fender. Position 1 (bridge humbucker) for the lead. It's thicker, and it hits the Green OD harder, so double-stops thicken up.

GP-5 settings

Module order: NR, PRE, DST, AMP, CAB, EQ, MOD, DLY, RVB.

NR -- Gate (always on)

- THRE: 18

Light gate. Only hum cleanup between phrases.

Kept low so the spring tail isn't chopped.

PRE -- off

Donner Ultimate Comp on the board handles evening out the chug.

DST -- Green OD (CTL)

- Gain: 18, Tone: 60, VOL: 68

- CTL Off = off, CTL On = on

Not a distortion. A level and grit push, like an early-60s Fender turned up for the solo.

Gain 18 puts just a little hair on the double-stops.

VOL 68 is the main job: the lead jumps about 3-4dB over the rhythm.

Tone 60 keeps the TS mid hump from making it sound like a 70s blues tone.

AMP/CAB -- NAM SnapTone, slot 61: TwinClean (always on)

- Built from the `CLEANEST - Fender Deluxe Reverb 1965 [Hyper Accuracy]` NAM and the TWIN REVERB

___ CLEAN (vulturized Twin) IR, combined into one snaptone.

- 1965 blackface Deluxe Reverb at its cleanest setting. It shares the Twin's blackface preamp circuit, so here it's the amp half of a Twin clean, into a real Twin 2x12 (JBL D120F) IR. Rebuilt 2026-09-26: the original TwinClean used the Tim R Twin Normal-channel capture, which was dropped for being too quiet.
- Surf guitar is a bright, clean Fender.
- Gain: 51, VOL: 75, Bass: 45, Middle: 50, Treble: 66
- Gain 51: a little over default. This part wants more push than the other TwinClean patches.
- Bass 45: low end pulled back a little.
- Middle 50: flat.
- Treble 66: more top end.
- VOL 75: the level Michael set for this snaptone in the 2026-10-01 VOL audit. Trim here if the patch jumps in level against your others.
- Same in both CTL states. AMP and CAB are off in the `.prst`, so nothing stacks on the capture. The N->S block calls slot 61 directly.

EQ -- Guitar EQ 1 (always on)

- 125Hz: -3, 400Hz: -2, 800Hz: +1, 1.6kHz: +3, 4kHz: +3, VOL: 50
- 3 at 125Hz and -2 at 400Hz clean out mud from the low-string chug.
- +3 at 1.6kHz and 4kHz is the jangle and pick attack that makes the record sound "bright".
- Same in both CTL states.

MOD -- off

No modulation on the record.

DLY -- Slapback (CTL)

- Mix: 20, Time: 110ms, F.Back: 8, Trail: On
- CTL Off = off, CTL On = on

Single, short repeat. Early-60s tape slap flavor on the lead.

Adds size to the double-stops without smearing fast lines.

Off for the rhythm. A slap on a fast 8th chug just clutters the groove.

RVB -- Spring (always on)

- Mix: 26, Decay: 40, Trail: On

The surf ingredient. Fender tank splash on every stab.

Mix 26: audible, but backed off from surf-instrumental levels. The vocals are the focus on this record.

CTL summary

- **CTL Off (rhythm):** NR + TwinClean snaptone + EQ + Spring. Bright, clean, splashy straight-8th chug.
- **CTL On (lead):** adds Green OD (level/grit push) + Slapback. The lead lines come forward with a little hair and a single slap repeat.
- Hit CTL for the intro lick, and before the instrumental break. Drop it as the next vocal line comes in.

Full Pedalboard

Signal chain order: Flamma FS-08 Octave -> Donner Ultimate Comp -> Donner Stylish Fuzz -> Joyo King of Kings -> Joyo Narcissus -> Valeton GP-5.

Flamma FS-08 Octave -- bypassed

- -2OCT: 0, -OCT: 0, +OCT: 0, +2OCT: 0, Dry: 100
- Footswitch: off for the whole song

No octave voice. Straight Fender guitar.

Donner Ultimate Comp -- engaged always

- COMP: 28, TONE: 60, LEVEL: 55, Mode: NORMAL

A light squeeze keeps the fast chug level from bar to bar.

COMP 28 keeps it transparent. You don't want to hear an obvious squash on a 1963 record.

TONE 60 and NORMAL mode. The amp's Bright switch is already supplying the top end.

Donner Stylish Fuzz -- bypassed

- Footswitch: off

No fuzz on this record.

Joyo King of Kings -- both channels bypassed

- Left: bypassed. Footswitch off. Parked at Volume 50, Gain 15, Tone 60, Clipping toggle: softer/asymmetric position, Feedback toggle: standard position.
- Right: bypassed. Footswitch off. Parked at Volume 50, Gain 25, Tone 60, Clipping toggle: softer/asymmetric position, Feedback toggle: standard position.

Neither channel is used. The GP-5's Green OD on CTL already does the lead push.

A board OD can't follow the GP-5 CTL switch. Running it always on would add grit to a rhythm that has to stay clean.

Joyo Narcissus -- bypassed

- Mode: Vintage, Width: 30, Depth: 20, Rate: 25 (parked)
- Footswitch: off

No chorus. Chorus pedals didn't exist in 1963, and it would blur the spring.

Valeton GP-5

See GP-5 settings above.

The `.prst` only carries the GP-5's 9 modules. The pedalboard settings above are not stored in the file. Set them by hand.